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while Ancelotti and Hayes were named the best coaches.

#### A tale of contrasts

For Lionel Messi, 2024 was a gratifying year. After leading Argentina to Copa America glory, he also captained Inter Miami to its first-ever MLS Supporters' Shield with a record 74 points. The victory secured his record-extending 46th career trophy.

For Cristiano Ronaldo, the wait for a Saudi Pro League title continued as Al Nassr lost to arch-rival Al Hilal, which won the league by 14 points.

However, Ronaldo achieved another milestone, scoring his 900th career goal in a Nations League match against Croatia, which Portugal won 2-1.



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# IN 2025...

Apart from the usual club football and international fixtures, the biggest event in the 2025 footballing calendar has to be the FIFA Club World Cup, where Manchester City is the defending champion. Scheduled to be played in the United States from June 14 to July 23, the tournament, which has undergone a major revamp, will now feature 32 teams, including the winners of the four previous continental championships.

Clubs under UEFA have 12 slots, CONMEBOL clubs have six, and four slots each have been allotted for CAF, CONCACAF, and AFC clubs. Host country USA will be represented by Lionel Messi's Inter Miami, which won the MLS Supporters' Shield.

There's also the impending verdict on Manchester City's Premier League rule breaches. While there has been no official confirmation, reports suggest that, if found guilty, punishments could be as harsh as City being stripped of its titles and being relegated to the second division. It remains to be seen what unfolds in this long-drawn saga.

Apart from the usual club competitions, 2025 is a significant year for women's international football. England will defend its European Championship title starting in July. The CAF Women's Africa Cup of Nations (AFCON) and CONMEBOL Copa América Femenina are also scheduled for 2025.

The Men's AFCON will commence in December, while the FIFA U-20 World Cup is also scheduled to take place between September and October.